

A BIBLICAL GUIDE TO GROWTH, MATURITY,
AND MAKING DISCIPLES

DISCIPLESHIP

Following Jesus and Becoming Like Him

PART 1



GRACEPATH
NETWORK

GROWING IN CHRIST. WALKING IN GRACE. IMPACTING LIVES.

DISCIPLESHIP

PART ONE

Introduction

Discipleship is the foundation of the Christian life. Jesus Christ did not simply invite people to believe in Him; He called them to follow Him, learn from Him, and become like Him. From the beginning of His ministry, Jesus sought men and women who would walk with Him, obey His teachings, and continue His mission in the world. His final instruction to His followers was clear: "**Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations**" (Matthew 28:19).

Part One of this discipleship course is designed to help believers establish a strong spiritual foundation. Whether you are a new Christian seeking direction or a mature believer desiring deeper growth, these lessons will guide you in understanding what it truly means to follow Jesus Christ.

In this section, we will examine the meaning of discipleship, the cost of following Jesus, and the wonderful gift of salvation and the assurance believers have in Christ. These truths are essential because a healthy Christian life begins with knowing who Jesus is, understanding His call upon our lives, and responding with wholehearted commitment.

Discipleship is more than attending church services, possessing biblical knowledge, or participating in religious activities. It is a lifelong journey of transformation. As disciples spend time with Jesus through prayer, Scripture, fellowship, and obedience, the Holy Spirit shapes them into Christlike men and women who influence others for God's kingdom.

The purpose of this study is not merely to increase information but to encourage spiritual formation. God desires believers who reflect His character, demonstrate His love, and faithfully serve others. True disciples grow personally and intentionally invest in helping others grow in their relationship with Christ.

May these lessons challenge you to pursue Jesus with renewed passion, deepen your faith, and strengthen your commitment to live as a faithful disciple who glorifies God and makes disciples of others.

Theme Scripture

Matthew 28:19–20 (NKJV)

"Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age." Amen.

Opening Prayer

Heavenly Father,

Thank You for calling me to follow Jesus Christ. Open my heart to receive Your truth and give me a desire to grow in faith, obedience, and love. Teach me through these lessons and transform my life by Your Holy Spirit. Help me become a faithful disciple who honours You and leads others to Christ.

In Jesus' name, Amen.

CHAPTER 1

What Is a Disciple?

Theme Scripture

Matthew 4:19 (NKJV)

"Then He said to them, 'Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.'"

Key Verse

Luke 6:40 (NKJV)

"A disciple is not above his teacher, but everyone who is perfectly trained will be like his teacher."

Introduction

One of the most important questions every believer should ask is, **"What does it mean to be a disciple of Jesus Christ?"**

Many people identify themselves as Christians because they attend church, belong to a Christian family, or participate in religious activities. However, Jesus calls His followers to something much deeper. He calls them to become disciples.

Discipleship is not a temporary program or a short course. It is a lifelong journey of learning, growing, obeying, and becoming more like Jesus. The goal of discipleship is transformation—not merely gaining information but developing a Christlike character and lifestyle.

Jesus spent much of His earthly ministry teaching and training twelve ordinary men. They listened to His teachings, watched His example, travelled with Him, and learned to minister to others. After His resurrection, these disciples became bold witnesses who carried the Gospel throughout the world.

Today, Jesus still calls men and women to follow Him and become His disciples.

What Is a Disciple?

The word **disciple** means *learner, student, follower, or apprentice*.

A disciple of Jesus Christ is someone who:

- Has trusted Jesus Christ as Lord and Saviour.

- Learns from Jesus through His Word.
- Obeys His teachings.
- Seeks to become like Him.
- Helps others follow Jesus.

A disciple is not simply someone who knows about Jesus. A disciple personally knows Jesus and walks with Him daily.

Characteristics of a True Disciple

1. A Disciple Loves Jesus Above Everything Else

Scripture

Luke 14:26 (NKJV)

"If anyone comes to Me and does not hate his father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters, yes, and his own life also, he cannot be My disciple."

Jesus was not teaching hatred toward family members. He was emphasizing that our love and commitment to Him should be greater than every other relationship.

Following Christ requires wholehearted devotion.

Practical Application

Ask yourself:

- Is Jesus first in my life?
- Do I seek His will before making decisions?

- Am I willing to obey Him even when it is difficult?
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2. A Disciple Abides in God's Word

Scripture

John 8:31 (NKJV)

"If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed."

God's Word nourishes and strengthens believers.

A disciple develops a habit of reading, studying, memorizing, and applying Scripture.

Suggestions for Bible Reading

Read daily.

Keep a notebook.

Highlight important verses.

Pray over what you read.

Practice what you learn.

3. A Disciple Bears Fruit

Scripture

John 15:8 (NKJV)

"By this My Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit; so you will be My disciples."

Spiritual fruit demonstrates spiritual growth.

Examples include:

Love

Joy

Peace

Patience

Kindness

Goodness

Faithfulness

Gentleness

Self-control

A fruitful disciple also influences others for Christ.

4. A Disciple Loves Other Believers

Scripture

John 13:35 (NKJV)

"By this all will know that you are My disciples, if you have love for one another."

Love is the distinguishing mark of Christian discipleship.

Love forgives.

Love serves.

Love encourages.

Love restores.

Love seeks unity among believers.

5. A Disciple Makes Other Disciples

Scripture

Matthew 28:19–20 (NKJV)

"Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations..."

Healthy disciples reproduce spiritually.

Every believer can help others grow by:

Teaching

Mentoring

Encouraging

Praying

Sharing testimonies

Leading Bible studies

Inviting others to church

Obstacles to Discipleship

Several challenges can hinder spiritual growth.

Worldliness

Allowing worldly values to shape our priorities.

Fear

Being afraid to stand for Christ.

Laziness

Neglecting prayer, Bible study, and fellowship.

Unforgiveness

Holding bitterness toward others.

Pride

Refusing correction and accountability.

Through the help of the Holy Spirit, these obstacles can be overcome.

Illustration

A young tree must be watered regularly and protected from strong winds. Over time, its roots grow deep, and it becomes strong enough to withstand storms.

Likewise, a disciple grows stronger by spending time with Jesus, obeying His Word, and remaining connected to other believers.

Reflection Questions

1. What does being a disciple mean to you?
2. Which characteristic of a disciple do you need to develop most?
3. What obstacles have hindered your spiritual growth?
4. How can you intentionally help someone else grow in Christ?

Memory Verse

Matthew 4:19 (NKJV)

"Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men."

Prayer

Lord Jesus,

Thank You for calling me to follow You. Teach me to love You wholeheartedly, obey Your Word, and become more like You each day. Help me bear fruit that glorifies God and empower me to lead others into a deeper relationship with You.

Amen.

CHAPTER 2

The Cost of Following Jesus

Theme Scripture

Luke 9:23 (NKJV)

"Then He said to them all, 'If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow Me.'"

Key Verse

Luke 14:27 (NKJV)

"And whoever does not bear his cross and come after Me cannot be My disciple."

Introduction

Many people desire the blessings of Christianity but hesitate when they discover the demands of discipleship. Jesus never hid the fact that following Him would require sacrifice, commitment, and perseverance.

Crowds followed Jesus because they were amazed by His miracles, attracted by His teachings, or interested in receiving physical blessings. However, Jesus desired more than admirers; He desired committed disciples.

Discipleship is not merely believing in Jesus when life is easy. It is remaining faithful to Him during seasons of joy, hardship, uncertainty, and persecution. True disciples understand that Jesus is worthy of complete devotion and that no earthly sacrifice can compare with the eternal rewards found in Him.

Before constructing a building, a wise builder counts the cost. Likewise, before committing ourselves to discipleship, we should understand what it means to follow Jesus wholeheartedly.

1. Discipleship Requires Self-Denial

Scripture

Luke 9:23 (NKJV)

"If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow Me."

Self-denial does not mean hating ourselves or neglecting our legitimate needs. It means surrendering our personal ambitions, desires, and priorities to the will of God.

Jesus Himself demonstrated self-denial.

Philippians 2:8 (NKJV)

"And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross."

Practical Examples of Self-Denial

- Choosing obedience over convenience.
- Forgiving those who have hurt us.
- Giving generously even when it is difficult.
- Serving others without seeking recognition.
- Refusing sinful pleasures that dishonour God.

Reflection

What personal desires or ambitions do I need to surrender to Christ?

2. Taking Up the Cross

The cross was a symbol of suffering, shame, and sacrifice during the time of Jesus.

To take up our cross means being willing to endure difficulties for the sake of Christ.

Some believers face ridicule because of their faith.

Others experience rejection from friends or family members.

In some countries, Christians face imprisonment and persecution.

Yet Jesus encourages His followers to remain faithful.

Matthew 10:22 (NKJV)

"And you will be hated by all for My name's sake. But he who endures to the end will be saved."

3. Loving Jesus Above Everything Else

Scripture

Luke 14:26 (NKJV)

"If anyone comes to Me and does not hate his father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters, yes, and his own life also, he cannot be My disciple."

Jesus was using strong language to emphasize priorities.

Our devotion to Christ should surpass every other relationship.

God does not command believers to neglect their families. Instead, He teaches that our loyalty to Him must come first.

Questions to Consider

- Is Jesus first in my life?
 - Would I obey Him if others disagreed?
 - Am I willing to stand for truth even when it is unpopular?
-

4. Counting the Cost

Scripture

Luke 14:28–30 (NKJV)

"For which of you, intending to build a tower, does not sit down first and count the cost, whether he has enough to finish it?"

Jesus compared discipleship to constructing a tower.

Wise builders prepare before they begin.

Likewise, disciples should understand that following Christ demands perseverance and commitment.

The Cost May Include

- Giving up sinful habits.
- Losing worldly approval.
- Sacrificing comfort.

- Investing time in prayer and Bible study.
- Serving faithfully in ministry.

However, the blessings of following Jesus far outweigh the sacrifices.

5. The Rewards of Discipleship

Jesus never asks His followers to sacrifice without purpose.

Mark 10:29–30 (NKJV)

"Assuredly, I say to you, there is no one who has left house or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands, for My sake and the gospel's, who shall not receive a hundredfold now in this time... and in the age to come, eternal life."

Rewards Include

- A deeper relationship with God.
 - Inner peace and joy.
 - Spiritual maturity.
 - Opportunities to impact others.
 - Eternal rewards in heaven.
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Biblical Examples

Peter and Andrew

They left their fishing nets immediately and followed Jesus.

(Matthew 4:18–20)

Matthew

Matthew abandoned a profitable career as a tax collector to become a disciple.

(Matthew 9:9)

Paul

Paul gave up status, influence, and personal achievements for Christ.

Philippians 3:8 (NKJV)

"Yet indeed I also count all things loss for the excellence of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord."

Obstacles to Commitment

Fear

Fear of rejection or suffering can hinder discipleship.

Materialism

Love for possessions can distract believers from serving God.

Busyness

An overcrowded schedule may leave little room for spiritual growth.

Divided Loyalties

Trying to serve both God and worldly desires weakens commitment.

Reflection Questions

1. What sacrifices have you made to follow Jesus?
 2. Are there areas where your commitment to Christ is being challenged?
 3. What fears keep you from obeying God fully?
 4. How do the rewards of discipleship encourage you to persevere?
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Memory Verse

Luke 9:23 (NKJV)

"If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow Me."

Prayer

Lord Jesus,

Thank You for calling me to follow You. Give me courage to deny myself, carry my cross daily, and remain faithful regardless of the challenges I may face. Help me to love You above all else and to trust that Your rewards are greater than any sacrifice I make.

In Jesus' name,

Amen.

Points to Remember

- Discipleship requires commitment.
- Following Jesus involves self-denial.
- Taking up our cross means enduring hardship for Christ.
- Jesus deserves first place in every area of our lives.
- The rewards of faithful discipleship are eternal.

CHAPTER 3

Salvation and Assurance of Salvation

Theme Scripture

John 3:16 (NKJV)

“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”

Key Verse

Romans 10:9 (NKJV)

“That if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved.”

Introduction

The greatest need of every human being is salvation. People seek happiness, success, wealth, and recognition, yet none of these can remove sin or reconcile humanity to God. The Bible teaches that salvation is God's gracious provision through Jesus Christ.

Many believers struggle with doubts concerning their salvation. They wonder whether they are truly saved or fear losing their relationship with God whenever they fail. God desires His children to have confidence in His promises and to live with the assurance that they belong to Him.

This chapter explains what salvation is, why it is necessary, how it is received, and how believers can know they are truly saved.

1. Why Do We Need Salvation?

Scripture

Romans 3:23 (NKJV)

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.”

Sin entered the world through Adam and affected all humanity.

Every person has sinned through thoughts, words, attitudes, and actions.

Sin separates people from God.

Isaiah 59:2 (NKJV)

“But your iniquities have separated you from your God.”

Without salvation, humanity remains spiritually dead and under the judgment of sin.

Romans 6:23 (NKJV)

“For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.”

2. God's Provision for Salvation

God loves humanity and desires everyone to be saved.

John 3:16 (NKJV)

“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son...”

Jesus Christ came into the world to save sinners.

He lived a sinless life.

He died on the cross.

He shed His blood for our sins.

He rose from the dead.

1 Peter 3:18 (NKJV)

“For Christ also suffered once for sins, the just for the unjust, that He might bring us to God.”

Salvation is entirely the work of God.

No human effort can earn it.

3. Salvation Is Received by Faith

Ephesians 2:8–9 (NKJV)

“For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast.”

Salvation is not obtained through:

- Good deeds
- Church membership

- Baptism
- Giving money
- Religious traditions

Salvation is received by placing faith in Jesus Christ.

Acts 16:31 (NKJV)

“Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and you will be saved.”

4. Repentance

Repentance means turning away from sin and turning toward God.

True repentance involves:

A Change of Mind

Recognizing sin as offensive to God.

A Change of Heart

Feeling sorrow for wrongdoing.

A Change of Direction

Choosing to obey God.

Acts 3:19 (NKJV)

“Repent therefore and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out.”

Repentance is not perfection.

Believers still struggle with weaknesses, but they continually seek God's forgiveness and help.

5. Assurance of Salvation

God wants believers to have confidence in their salvation.

1 John 5:13 (NKJV)

“These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life.”

Assurance is based upon God's promises, not emotions.

Some days believers may feel spiritually strong.

Other days they may feel discouraged.

Our salvation rests upon Christ's finished work, not changing feelings.

6. Evidence of Salvation

Several signs indicate genuine spiritual life.

A Desire to Obey God

Saved people desire to please God.

Love for Other Believers

1 John 3:14 (NKJV)

“We know that we have passed from death to life, because we love the brethren.”

Conviction of Sin

The Holy Spirit convicts believers when they sin.

Spiritual Growth

Believers gradually become more like Jesus.

Hunger for God's Word

A growing desire to study Scripture.

7. What Happens When a Christian Sins?

Christians are not perfect.

They may stumble and fall.

However, God invites believers to confess their sins.

1 John 1:9 (NKJV)

“If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

God's forgiveness restores fellowship.

Believers should not remain in guilt and condemnation.

Romans 8:1 (NKJV)

“There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus.”

Illustration

A child may disobey his father and require correction, but he does not stop being his father's child.

Likewise, believers may fail, but God's love remains steadfast, and He lovingly restores those who repent.

Reflection Questions

1. Why is salvation necessary?
 2. Why can't good works save us?
 3. What is the difference between repentance and regret?
 4. What evidence of salvation do you see in your life?
 5. How would you explain salvation to a friend?
-

Memory Verse

Ephesians 2:8–9 (NKJV)

“For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast.”

Prayer

Heavenly Father,

Thank You for loving me and providing salvation through Jesus Christ. Help me to trust fully in Your grace and to live with confidence in Your promises. Strengthen my faith, deepen my love for You, and help me grow into a mature disciple of Christ.

In Jesus' name,

Amen.

Points to Remember

- Every person needs salvation because all have sinned.
- Jesus Christ died and rose again to save humanity.
- Salvation is received by grace through faith.
- Repentance means turning from sin to God.
- Believers can have assurance of salvation because God keeps His promises.
- Spiritual growth and obedience provide evidence of genuine faith.

- **Conclusion – Discipleship Part 1**
- As we conclude Part One of this discipleship journey, we are reminded that following Jesus Christ is both a privilege and a responsibility. We have learned that a disciple is more than a church attendee or a person with religious knowledge. A disciple is someone who has responded to Christ's call, trusted Him as Saviour, and chosen to follow Him wholeheartedly.
- We have discovered that discipleship involves commitment, sacrifice, and perseverance. Jesus calls His followers to deny themselves, take up their cross daily, and place Him above every earthly attachment. Though the path of discipleship may sometimes be challenging, it leads to a deeper relationship with God, spiritual maturity, and eternal rewards.
- We have also seen that salvation is God's gracious gift, received through faith in Jesus Christ alone. Because of His finished work on the cross, believers can live with confidence and assurance, knowing that they belong to God and have the promise of eternal life. As we continue growing in Christ, the Holy Spirit transforms us, helping us bear spiritual fruit and become effective witnesses for His kingdom.
- Part One has laid the foundation for a lifelong journey of discipleship. The lessons ahead will build upon these truths, equipping believers to develop spiritual disciplines, serve faithfully,

overcome challenges, and help others become devoted followers of Jesus Christ.

- May your desire to know Christ deepen each day. May you remain steadfast in your faith, obedient to His Word, and committed to making disciples wherever God places you. Remember that discipleship is not a destination but a continual walk with Jesus until the day we see Him face to face.
- **Closing Scripture**
- **Philippians 1:6 (NKJV)**
- *"Being confident of this very thing, that He who has begun a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ."*
- **Closing Prayer**
- **Heavenly Father,**
- Thank You for the truths we have learned in this section of our discipleship journey. Help us to remain faithful to Your calling, obedient to Your Word, and dependent upon Your Holy Spirit. Continue shaping us into the image of Christ so that our lives may glorify You and lead others to salvation. Strengthen us for the journey ahead and use us to make disciples who will impact the world for Your kingdom.
- **In Jesus' name, Amen.**

DISCIPLESHIP – PART 1

Final Examination

Name: _____

Church: _____

Date: _____

SECTION A: MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

Choose the correct answer. (2 marks each)

1. A disciple is best described as:
 - A. A church member
 - B. A learner and follower of Jesus Christ
 - C. A pastor
 - D. A Bible teacher
2. Jesus called His disciples to become:
 - A. Kings
 - B. Priests
 - C. Fishers of men
 - D. Prophets
3. According to Luke 9:23, believers are to take up their cross:
 - A. Weekly
 - B. Monthly
 - C. Daily
 - D. Yearly
4. Salvation is received through:
 - A. Good works
 - B. Church attendance
 - C. Baptism

- D. Faith in Jesus Christ
5. Which of the following is NOT a characteristic of a disciple?
- A. Loving Jesus
 - B. Bearing fruit
 - C. Seeking revenge
 - D. Loving other believers
6. The wages of sin is:
- A. Wealth
 - B. Death
 - C. Blessing
 - D. Fame
7. Repentance means:
- A. Feeling guilty
 - B. Turning from sin to God
 - C. Joining a church
 - D. Giving offerings
8. Which Scripture is known as the Great Commission?
- A. John 3:16
 - B. Matthew 28:19–20
 - C. Psalm 23
 - D. Romans 8:1
9. Assurance of salvation is based upon:
- A. Emotions
 - B. Feelings
 - C. God's promises
 - D. Experiences
10. Jesus taught that His followers should love Him:

- A. Occasionally
 - B. Above everything else
 - C. Only during worship
 - D. More than friends only
-

SECTION B: TRUE OR FALSE

Write True or False. (2 marks each)

11. A disciple only learns about Jesus but does not follow Him. _____
 12. Salvation can be earned through good works. _____
 13. A believer may struggle with sin but can receive forgiveness. _____
 14. Discipleship is a lifelong journey. _____
 15. Fear and worldliness can hinder spiritual growth. _____
 16. Jesus wants admirers rather than committed disciples. _____
 17. Christians can know they have eternal life. _____
 18. Spiritual fruit includes love, joy, and peace. _____
 19. Self-denial means surrendering our desires to God. _____
 20. Repentance involves a change of direction. _____
-

SECTION C: SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS

Answer briefly. (5 marks each)

21. What is a disciple?

22. Mention four characteristics of a true disciple.

a) _____

b) _____

c) _____

d) _____

23. Name three obstacles to discipleship.

a) _____

b) _____

c) _____

24. What does it mean to take up your cross daily?

25. Why do people need salvation?

26. Give three evidences of genuine salvation.

a) _____

b) _____

c) _____

SECTION D: ESSAY QUESTIONS

Answer any TWO questions. (15 marks each)

27. Explain the cost of following Jesus and discuss the rewards of discipleship.

28. Describe how salvation is received and how a believer can have assurance of salvation.

29. Explain the difference between information and transformation in discipleship.

MEMORY VERSES

- **Matthew 4:19**
- **Luke 9:23**
- **Ephesians 2:8–9**

DISCIPLESHIP

PART 1

Following Jesus and Becoming Like Him

Discipleship is more than attending church or knowing about Jesus—it is a lifelong journey of following Him, becoming like Him, and helping others do the same.

Discipleship Part 1 lays the foundation for every believer. Discover what it means to be a true disciple, the cost and rewards of following Jesus, and the assurance we have in God's gift of salvation.

Let this book inspire you to grow deeper in your faith, walk in grace, and make a lasting impact for God's Kingdom.



BIBLICAL TEACHING

Rooted in God's Word.



SPIRITUAL GROWTH

Grow in faith and maturity.



MAKE DISCIPLES

Impact lives for eternity.



ETERNAL PURPOSE

Live for God's glory.



"Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age." Amen.

MATTHEW 28:19–20 (NKJV)



GRACEPATH
NETWORK

GROWING IN CHRIST.
WALKING IN GRACE.
IMPACTING LIVES.



SCAN TO DISCOVER MORE

Free resources, discipleship tools,
and encouragement for your journey.



Email: gracepathnetwork@gmail.com